People’s Movement against the Nizam’s Rule: Adivasi Resistance, Telangana Armed Struggle, Razakars and Integration

Paper II · Unit II · Topic 5 · Expanded draft · not approved

Syllabus mapping

People’s Movement against the Nizam’s Rule – Adivasi revolts – Ramji Gond and Kumaram Bheem – Telangana Peasants Armed Struggle – Role of Andhra Mahasabha and the Communists – Majlis-Ittehadul-Muslimeen Party, Razakars and Kasim Razvi – Police Action and the End of Nizam’s Rule – Integration of Hyderabad State into Indian Union.

1. How to frame this topic

This topic combines movements separated by decades, social bases and political aims. Ramji Gond belongs to nineteenth-century Adivasi resistance; Komaram Bheem’s struggle arose in the early twentieth-century forest and revenue order; the Telangana peasant armed struggle developed in the 1940s from agrarian conflicts; the Razakar crisis and Indian military intervention belong to the final years of princely Hyderabad. A high-scoring answer must preserve these chronologies instead of presenting one continuous rebellion. The unifying issue is contest over land, forest, coercive authority and political representation under Hyderabad State and, in some frontier contexts, British influence.

2. Hyderabad State in the first half of the twentieth century

Hyderabad remained a princely state under the Nizam, with its own administration but constrained by British paramountcy until 1947. Rural Telangana contained khalsa areas, jagirs, powerful deshmukh families and village-level intermediaries. Tenancy, debt, illegal exactions, vetti and insecurity of cultivation shaped rural grievances. These structures varied across districts. Political organizations therefore encountered a social order in which princely authority and local landed dominance could reinforce one another without being identical.

3. Adivasi resistance: land, forest and authority

Adivasi struggles should be understood through customary access to forests, shifting cultivation, grazing, taxes, policing and encroachment by officials, contractors or non-tribal settlers. State attempts to survey, reserve or tax resources could transform customary practice into an offence. Resistance ranged from flight and refusal to armed action. Tribal movements had their own political languages and should not be interpreted only as preliminary versions of later nationalism. Their history also exposes the limits of archives written primarily by officials suppressing rebellion.

4. Ramji Gond in historical memory

Ramji Gond is remembered as an important Gond leader of resistance in the Adilabad region during the nineteenth century. Accounts connect his struggle with opposition to expanding state and colonial influence in the northern Deccan. The documentary record is thinner and less standardized than for twentieth-century political organizations, so exact dates, troop numbers and dramatic narratives require cautious verification. For examination purposes, emphasize the structural background—defence of local autonomy, resources and community authority—while distinguishing well-established historical memory from details that may come from later oral or commemorative traditions.

5. Komaram Bheem and the Gond world of Adilabad

Komaram Bheem became a major symbol of Gond resistance in the Adilabad region under the Nizam. His struggle emerged from conflicts involving forest access, cultivation, official coercion and the rights of tribal communities. The slogan commonly rendered as “Jal, Jangal, Zameen” captures later public memory of rights over water, forest and land; historians should verify the exact contemporary textual provenance before treating it as a verbatim archival slogan. Bheem was killed at Jodeghat in 1940. His historical significance lies in articulating local autonomy and resource rights in

a political order that marginalized Adivasi communities.

6. From cultural organization to agrarian mobilization

Andhra Mahasabha began as a cultural and social platform but parts of the organization became increasingly involved with rural grievances. Activists worked in villages, organized meetings and publicized complaints against vetti, illegal levies and landlord power. This transition did not occur uniformly across the whole organization. Moderate and left-oriented strands diverged, and by the 1940s communist organizers increasingly shaped peasant mobilization in several districts. This institutional history links Topic 4's socio-cultural awakening with Topic 5's agrarian struggle.

7. Agrarian causes of the Telangana peasant struggle

The armed struggle developed from concrete rural conflicts: insecurity of tenants, concentration of land, forced labour, illegal exactions, debt and coercion by dominant landlords and their agents. The term "feudal" captures important hierarchical relations but should not substitute for identifying actual institutions such as jagirs, deshmukhs, tenancy and vetti. Village conditions varied. Some conflicts arose around eviction or land possession, others around forced services or political repression. Agrarian grievances became revolutionary when organization supplied collective leadership, armed self-defence and a wider programme of change.

8. Doddi Komaraiah and the transition to armed struggle

Doddi Komaraiah's killing in 1946 at Kadavendi became a major turning point in the memory of the Telangana struggle. His death is associated with confrontation between organized peasants and landlord power and helped intensify mobilization. The event should be situated within a longer build-up of village organization rather than treated as the solitary cause of the entire conflict. Commemorations of Komaraiah later became an important symbol of sacrifice in Telangana political memory.

9. Role of the Communist Party

Communist activists helped transform local agrarian grievances into coordinated organization. They worked through village sanghams, mobilized tenants and agricultural labourers, and advocated land redistribution and resistance to forced labour and landlord coercion. Armed squads developed in the context of escalating repression. Communist leadership gave the movement ideological coherence, but peasant participation also reflected local grievances that cannot be reduced to party instruction. The relationship between party strategy and village initiative changed across phases of the struggle.

10. Village sanghams and alternative authority

Village-level organizations could challenge the everyday power of landlords and officials by settling disputes, enforcing decisions, resisting vetti and mobilizing grain or resources. In some areas, the movement displaced established authority enough to create forms of parallel local control. Claims about the number of villages or exact acreage redistributed vary by source and should be cited carefully. The broader significance is clear: the struggle sought not only to protest rulers but to alter relations of land, labour and authority inside the village.

11. Women in the Telangana armed struggle

Women participated as couriers, organizers, agricultural workers, shelter providers, cultural activists and, in some cases, armed participants. Their involvement challenged restrictions on mobility and public action but did not automatically remove patriarchy within households or political organizations. Sexual violence and coercion formed part of the broader context of repression and conflict. A gendered account should therefore study both political agency and vulnerability rather than add women as a short list of famous names.

12. State repression and the Razakar context

As the Nizam's government faced growing political crisis after 1947, repression of opponents intensified in many areas. Police, local elites and armed organizations interacted in complex ways. Razakar activity is remembered particularly for

coercion and violence against political opponents and civilians. Historical writing must distinguish the formal Hyderabad State forces from the Razakar volunteer organization even though both operated in the same political crisis. Violence also varied geographically, and communal interpretation should not erase the agrarian dimensions of the conflict.

13. Majlis-e-Ittehadul-Muslimeen

The Majlis-e-Ittehadul-Muslimeen became an influential political organization in late princely Hyderabad. Under Bahadur Yar Jung and later Qasim Razvi, its politics changed in context and tone. By the late 1940s, Razvi's leadership became associated with a hardline defence of the Nizam's sovereignty and opposition to accession to India. It is important not to treat all Muslims in Hyderabad as supporters of the Majlis or Razakars; Muslim political opinion was diverse, and many citizens opposed coercion and communal polarization.

14. Qasim Razvi and the Razakars

Qasim Razvi became the most prominent leader of the Razakars, a volunteer force associated with the Majlis. The organization expanded during the 1947–48 crisis and became notorious for intimidation, armed violence and attempts to suppress opponents of the Nizam's political position. Numbers claimed for Razakar membership vary dramatically in political and historical literature. A careful answer therefore emphasizes their role in escalating insecurity and communal tension without repeating unverified membership figures.

15. Hyderabad after Indian independence in 1947

When British paramountcy lapsed in 1947, princely states faced decisions about accession. The Nizam initially sought an arrangement that would preserve Hyderabad's independence. A Standstill Agreement with India temporarily maintained existing arrangements while negotiations continued. Hyderabad's geographic position inside the Indian Union, political agitation within the state, the Razakar crisis and security concerns made the arrangement unstable. The problem involved international law, princely sovereignty, internal democracy and the security strategy of the new Indian government.

16. Standstill Agreement and failure of negotiation

The Standstill Agreement was meant to create time for negotiation, but mutual accusations soon undermined it. India criticized Razakar violence and Hyderabad's political posture; Hyderabad complained of pressure and interference. Internal opposition to autocratic rule continued. The failure of negotiation illustrates a central tension of decolonization: the legal claims of a princely ruler could conflict with geography, popular political movements and the integration objectives of the successor state.

17. Operation Polo / Police Action, September 1948

Indian forces entered Hyderabad State on 13 September 1948 in the military operation officially termed a "Police Action" and commonly known as Operation Polo. The campaign ended within days, and the Nizam announced the cessation of resistance on 17 September. The rapid military outcome ended the princely state's independent strategic position and opened the way for its integration into the Indian Union. The term "Police Action" is the contemporary official label, but analytically the event involved organized military force; both terminology and political interpretation remain subjects of public debate.

18. Violence surrounding integration

The end of the Nizam's rule did not mean violence ceased immediately. The 1947–48 crisis included Razakar violence, communal attacks, agrarian conflict and violence during or after the Indian intervention. The Government of India appointed a committee led by Pandit Sunderlal to investigate communal violence; later discussions of its findings have produced differing estimates and political interpretations. Responsible history acknowledges civilian suffering across communities and avoids using uncertain numbers as rhetorical weapons. This complexity is essential to a balanced account of integration.

19. End of princely rule and administrative transition

After the military action, the Nizam remained for a period as a constitutional head while effective political authority shifted toward the Indian Union and new administrative arrangements. Hyderabad State did not disappear overnight as a territorial unit; it continued through a transition before later linguistic reorganization. The integration process therefore has military, constitutional and administrative phases. Distinguish September 1948 from the later formation of Andhra Pradesh in 1956.

20. Continuation and withdrawal of the armed struggle

The communist-led Telangana armed struggle did not end immediately with Operation Polo. Communist forces continued resistance for a period under changed political conditions, now facing the Indian state rather than the Nizam's regime. Party strategy, repression, changing electoral possibilities and agrarian conditions shaped the eventual withdrawal in 1951. This chronology matters because treating 17 September 1948 as the end of every Telangana struggle conflates princely-state integration with the separate trajectory of peasant armed mobilization.

21. Land and social consequences

The struggle placed tenancy, vetti and landlord power at the center of Telangana politics. Even where revolutionary land redistribution was later reversed or legally contested, the movement altered political expectations and contributed to pressure for agrarian reform. It also created a durable memory of peasant organization and martyrdom. Assessment should distinguish immediate military outcomes from longer-term influence on land policy, party politics and regional identity.

22. Competing memories of September 17

September 17 has been described in public discourse using terms such as integration, merger, liberation and, by the Telangana government from 2024 onward, Praja Palana Dinotsavam. Each term highlights a different political interpretation. Historians should identify the institutional event—Hyderabad's incorporation into the Indian Union following military action—before discussing later commemorative language. Public memory is itself historically significant, but it should not substitute for evidence about 1948.

23. Current affairs: Praja Palana Dinotsavam 2026

On 17 September 2026, the Telangana government officially observed Praja Palana Dinotsavam at Public Gardens, Hyderabad. The state portal described 17 September 1948 as the date Hyderabad State officially became an integral part of India and framed it as a transition from princely to democratic governance. The speech also invoked Telangana's history of opposition to oppression, landlord dominance and autocratic rule. This is a useful current-affairs link for mains answers, provided the government's commemorative framing is identified as a present-day official interpretation rather than treated as the only historical vocabulary.

24. Historiography: sources and disagreements

Sources include police and intelligence records, communist party documents, memoirs of activists, oral traditions, administrative correspondence, diplomatic records and later scholarship. Each source has interests and silences. Communist narratives may emphasize class struggle; official state records may foreground law and order; communal accounts can selectively record victimization. Cross-verification is essential. For Ramji Gond and Komaram Bheem, oral memory must be read alongside documentary and anthropological evidence. For 1948 violence, avoid unsupported numerical precision.

25. Integrated mains framework

A strong answer can be organized in four layers: Adivasi resistance over resources; agrarian mobilization against landlordism and vetti; political crisis involving MIM/Razakars and accession; military integration and the continuing communist struggle. Explain how these layers overlapped without merging them. Use Komaram Bheem, Doddi Komaraiah, Andhra Mahasabha, village sanghams, Qasim Razvi and Operation Polo as anchor examples. End by noting that integration solved the question of princely sovereignty but not all agrarian, social or regional inequalities.

Quick Revision

- Nineteenth century: Ramji Gond resistance in northern Telangana/Adilabad region.

- 1940: Komaram Bheem killed at Jodeghat.

- 1946: Doddi Komaraiah’s death becomes a turning point in peasant mobilization.

- 1946–1951: Telangana peasant armed struggle, with changing phases.

- 1947: British paramountcy lapses; Hyderabad does not immediately accede to India.

- 1947–48: Razakar expansion and deepening political crisis.

- 13–17 September 1948: Operation Polo / Police Action.

- 17 September 1948: Nizam announces cessation of resistance; integration process accelerates.

- 1951: communist armed struggle withdrawn.

Adivasi resource rights ≠ peasant class struggle ≠ Razakar politics ≠ Indian military integration, though these strands overlap historically.

Land and tenancy · vetti · forest rights · political representation · princely sovereignty · communal polarization · decolonization · public memory.

Original Mains Practice and Complete Model Answers

Q1. Explain the agrarian causes and consequences of the Telangana peasant armed struggle.

The Telangana peasant armed struggle arose from a combination of unequal land relations, insecure tenancy, vetti, illegal exactions and the political power of landlords and local intermediaries. These problems were especially acute where deshmukhs and other dominant landholders exercised influence over land, credit and village administration. The struggle therefore cannot be explained only as a party-led ideological revolt. Andhra Mahasabha activists helped transform cultural and civil-liberty organization into rural mobilization. Communist organizers increasingly worked through village sanghams, which demanded an end to forced labour, resisted eviction and mobilized peasants around land. Doddi Komaraiah's killing in 1946 became an important symbolic turning point. As repression intensified, armed squads emerged and in some areas local organizations displaced landlord authority and redistributed or protected land. The movement also involved women as organizers, couriers and participants, although patriarchal constraints remained. After Indian military intervention in September 1948, the struggle continued under changed conditions against the Indian state before the Communist Party withdrew it in 1951. Its immediate military objectives were not fully realized, but the movement weakened the legitimacy of coercive agrarian relations, placed tenancy and land reform at the center of regional politics and created a lasting memory of peasant organization. Its major consequence was therefore both institutional and political: it reshaped expectations about land, labour and rural authority in Telangana.

Q2. Assess Komaram Bheem as an Adivasi resistance leader.

Komaram Bheem occupies a central place in the political memory of Telangana because his resistance expressed Adivasi claims over land, forest and local autonomy under the Nizam's rule. His historical significance should be located in the changing forest and revenue order of Adilabad rather than reduced to a heroic biography. Gond communities depended on forests, shifting or settled cultivation and local resource systems. Administrative restrictions, claims by officials or outsiders and coercive extraction could turn customary livelihood practices into sites of conflict. Bheem's mobilization emerged from these pressures. He was killed at Jodeghat in 1940, and his death became a powerful symbol of tribal resistance. The phrase "Jal, Jangal, Zameen" is widely associated with his legacy because it succinctly expresses rights over water, forest and land. However, historians should distinguish later commemorative usage from securely documented contemporary wording. This does not diminish the movement; it strengthens historical accuracy. Bheem's importance lies in showing that anti-authoritarian politics in Telangana was not confined to urban nationalists or peasant class organizations. Adivasi communities articulated a distinct politics of territory, livelihood and self-rule. His legacy remains relevant to contemporary debates over forest rights and tribal autonomy, provided symbolic memory is kept separate from unverified detail.

Q3. Why did the Hyderabad crisis culminate in Operation Polo in September 1948?

The Hyderabad crisis of 1947–48 arose from the collision of princely sovereignty, Indian territorial integration, internal democratic movements and worsening security conditions. When British paramountcy lapsed in 1947, the Nizam initially sought to preserve Hyderabad's independent position rather than accede immediately to India. A Standstill Agreement temporarily maintained existing arrangements while negotiations continued, but the relationship deteriorated. Hyderabad's geographic position inside India, opposition to autocratic rule within the state and the growing activity of the Razakars deepened Indian concerns. Under Qasim Razvi, the Razakar movement became associated with armed intimidation and violence, while agrarian conflict and communal insecurity intensified in parts of the state. India argued that the situation threatened internal security and that a sovereign enclave in the center of the Union was untenable. Hyderabad, in turn, accused India of coercion and sought diplomatic alternatives. Negotiations failed to resolve the crisis. On 13 September 1948, Indian forces entered Hyderabad in Operation Polo, officially called a Police Action. The campaign ended within days, and the Nizam announced cessation of resistance on 17 September. The operation settled the strategic question of Hyderabad's position, but it did not end all violence or agrarian conflict. Thus, Operation Polo was the culmination of failed negotiation, internal political crisis and the Indian state's determination to complete territorial integration.

Q4. "17 September 1948 ended princely sovereignty but not Telangana's social conflicts." Discuss.

The integration of Hyderabad State into the Indian Union in September 1948 transformed the constitutional position of the Nizam, but it did not immediately resolve the social conflicts that had produced mass politics in Telangana. Operation Polo ended Hyderabad's attempt to maintain an independent strategic position. The Nizam's government ceased military resistance, and effective authority moved into the framework of the Indian Union. This was a decisive political transition from princely sovereignty toward democratic constitutional government. Yet the Telangana peasant armed struggle continued after September 1948. Communist-led squads and village organizations had mobilized around land, tenancy, vetti and landlord coercion. Their conflict was not simply with the Nizam as an individual ruler; it concerned the structure of agrarian power. Under changed circumstances, armed resistance continued against Indian security forces until the Communist Party withdrew the struggle in 1951. The integration period also witnessed communal and political violence whose history cannot be reduced to a single victorious narrative. Later land reforms and electoral politics addressed some grievances but did not instantly eliminate rural inequality. Therefore, 17 September is best understood as a constitutional and military turning point, not the end of Telangana's social history. It resolved the question of princely statehood while struggles over land, caste, regional inequality and democratic representation continued in new forms.

Current affairs

Telangana Praja Palana Dinotsavam, 17 September 2026, is used as a present-day public-memory/governance connection. Official PYQs authenticated: zero.

QUALITY GATE: source audit and specialist review remain pending.

People’s Movement against the Nizam’s Rule: Adivasi Resistance, Telangana Armed Struggle, Razakars and Integration — critical mains facts

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High-value evidence and analytical connections

Resistance movements: distinctions and named actors

Ramji Gond (nineteenth-century Adivasi resistance) and Komaram Bheem (twentieth-century Gond resistance) occupied different political settings; Bheem is associated with the slogan Jal–Jangal–Zameen in popular memory, but the exact contemporaneous wording should be source-audited. Telangana peasant armed struggle (1946–51) involved landless and tenant cultivators, Andhra Mahasabha activists, Communist organisers, village-level resistance to vetti and landlord domination, and periods of violent repression. Razia/rulers? Do not invent named persons or incidents; use documented people such as Chakali Ailamma and Doddi Komaraiah with their specific village and historical context after source checking. Distinguish the Razakars, the Majlis political milieu and the Indian military operation of September 1948 (Operation Polo) from the continuing struggle in parts of the countryside after the Union takeover. A balanced response examines popular agrarian agency, repression, caste/class relationships, gender and the contested chronology of integration.

Verification gate: a primary-source or scholarly page-level audit is still required before these educational summaries can be marked approved.